



The Middle Ages and Scholasticism

HISTORY OF ECO. THOUGHT

Middle ages



The Medieval Ages, also known as the Middle Ages, spanned roughly from the 5th to the late 15th century in Europe, following the fall of the Western Roman Empire. It's divided into three periods: the Early, High, and Late Middle Ages.

Early Middle Ages (5th-10th century):

- ▶ This era was marked by the decline of centralized authority and the emergence of feudalism. Europe was characterized by decentralized kingdoms, and Christianity played a significant role in society.
- ▶ Monasteries preserved knowledge and served as centers of learning. The Carolingian Renaissance, initiated by Charlemagne, saw a revival of art, culture, and education.

High Middle Ages (11th-13th century):

- ▶ This period witnessed significant advancements in various fields. Feudalism was at its peak, with powerful monarchies emerging in Europe.
- ▶ The Crusades occurred, leading to cultural exchanges between Europe and the Middle East. Economic growth led to the rise of towns and cities, fostering trade and commerce. Universities were established, becoming hubs of intellectual activity.

Late Middle Ages (14th-15th century):

- ▶ This era was marked by significant challenges, including the Black Death, which devastated Europe's population. Social unrest and economic changes, such as the decline of feudalism and the rise of the bourgeoisie, occurred. The Hundred Years' War and the Great Schism of the Catholic Church further destabilized the continent.

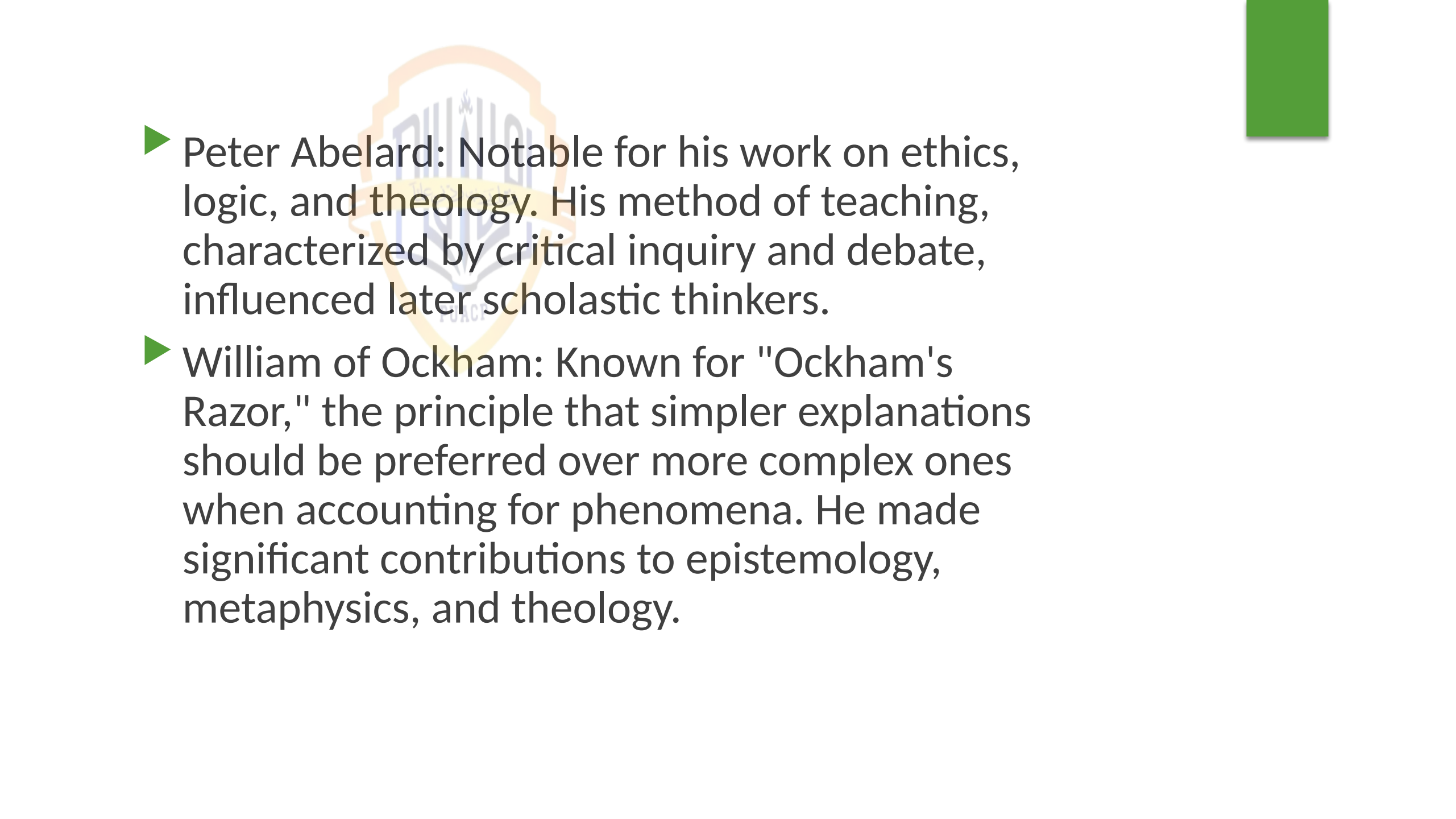
Scholasticism

- ▶ Scholasticism emerged during the High Middle Ages as a philosophical and theological system that sought to reconcile faith with reason, particularly within the Christian context.
- ▶ Key figures include St. Anselm, who proposed the ontological argument for the existence of God, and St. Thomas Aquinas, whose Summa Theologica integrated Aristotelian philosophy with Christian theology.

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- ▶ Scholasticism emphasized dialectical reasoning and the use of logic to explore theological and philosophical questions. It aimed to harmonize revelation (faith) with reason, believing that faith and reason were compatible and could complement each other in the pursuit of truth.
 - ▶ Universities, particularly those in Paris and Oxford, became centers of scholastic thought, where scholars engaged in debates and discussions on various topics. The method of scholastic inquiry influenced academic disciplines across Europe and laid the groundwork for the development of modern academic practices.

Key contributors

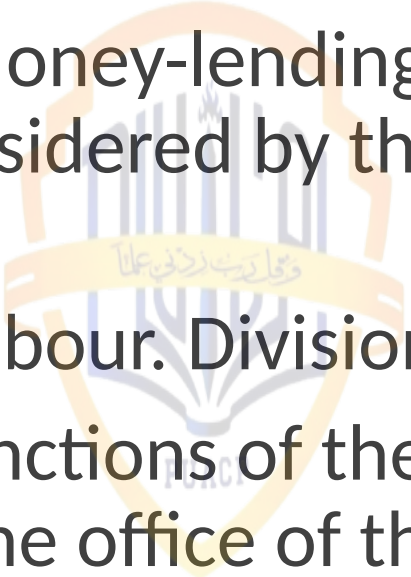
- ▶ **St. Anselm:** Known for his ontological argument for the existence of God, which posits that God is the greatest conceivable being whose existence is necessary.
- ▶ **St. Thomas Aquinas:** Arguably the most influential scholastic philosopher, Aquinas synthesized Aristotelian philosophy with Christian theology in works like the "Summa Theologica." He emphasized the compatibility of faith and reason and made significant contributions to ethics, metaphysics, and natural

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- ▶ Peter Abelard: Notable for his work on ethics, logic, and theology. His method of teaching, characterized by critical inquiry and debate, influenced later scholastic thinkers.
 - ▶ William of Ockham: Known for "Ockham's Razor," the principle that simpler explanations should be preferred over more complex ones when accounting for phenomena. He made significant contributions to epistemology, metaphysics, and theology.

St. Thomas Aquinas (1225-1274 A.D.)

-Most renowned scholastic philosopher. His Economic Views or Scholasticism:

1. Individualism. Schoolmen in general despised individualism and scorned the idea of laying emphasis on human personality as the basis for economic decisions
2. Property. St. Aquinas did not uphold the exclusive and unrestricted rights in private property.
3. Trade. St. Aquinas regarded trade neither good nor natural. It was unnatural and graceless Value was considered as an objective quality inherent in every commodity. Its measure was dependent upon a process of estimation of the cost of production which covered labour.
4. Just Price something like value was absolute and was associated with the common usefulness of the commodity.



5. Usury and Money-lending. Money-lending, as a means of gaining wealth was considered by the Church Fathers as the most degraded act.

6. Division of Labour. Division to labour was accepted as useful.

7. Economic Functions of the State. The state was likened to a private economy and the office of the ruler was regarded as private property. Aquinas believed that by money the king could purchase food for his subjects, in times of war.

The king, thus, possessed the right to control and regulate the monetary system and to make laws for the prevention of counterfeiting and clipping of coins. The regulation of currency was thought necessary, because a slight change in its quantity might affect its price.